

Chapter 80_1 - Destiny

She had never imagined that upon discovering the person who dual cultivated with her was Chu Qingqiu, her heart would feel such relief - as if she had swallowed a mouthful of warm sunlight, making her entire heart brilliant.

She sat on the bed for quite a while, surprised to discover that her mind had already wandered far away, sometimes recalling the sweetness of last night's lips, sometimes engaged in internal conflict.

The white her said: You see, what Jiuying said must be true. If she had no feelings for you, how could she humble her dignity as Chu Qingqiu to dual cultivate with you, and cry like pear blossoms in rain on the bed, saying those ambiguous words?

The black her retorted: Ning Fuyi, but don't forget - you died by her hand in your previous life. Even if she's very caring toward you in this life, it's only out of care for a good friend's descendant. Don't truly let your heart be moved!

The white her argued back: Care? Have you ever seen someone care for a descendant by caring for them in bed?

The black her grew angry: What about the mortal enmity of her taking your life? Are you going to ignore that? Have you forgotten the pain of that arrow through your heart?

The white one said: But what does the previous life have to do with this one? Chu Qingqiu didn't harbor evil intentions to kill you. She was a Divine Venerable and you were a demon lord. You even captured and tormented her for so long - even being pierced by an arrow through the heart wouldn't create such deep hatred, would it?

"Enough!" Ning Fuyi suddenly swept her hair behind her, casting off the argument within her heart.

Dwelling on this and that over one matter, being wishy-washy - this wasn't Ning Fuyi's style. If she cared, then she cared; if she didn't care, then she didn't. She had lived her whole life openly and honestly. Even when she was bad, she was bad honestly. There was no reason to hide away and shed secret tears.

Just as she was about to get out of bed, a breeze passed through the air, followed by a strong smell of alcohol. The not-yet-fully-awake Jiuying appeared before her in circles, her bright face flushed red, clearly just awakening from a hangover.

"Girl~" Jiuying wiped her lips and pounced toward her. Ning Fuyi immediately turned and stood up, looking down at the person who fell face-first onto the bed, her delicate hands gripping the bedding, all elegance gone.

Ning Fuyi waved her hand to dispel the alcohol smell in the room and laughed: "Qi Jiuying, you disappeared for a night - so you went drinking?"

"It was all because of Jiang Li and that stinky girl, saying that Point Star Town had a wine master who brewed wine that was unmatched in the mortal realm. That's how I got drunk by them and ended up lying in their wine shop all night. I'm still not sober now."

Suddenly inviting someone to drink for no reason? Ning Fuyi pursed her lips - it must have been that Chu Qingqiu had planned this in advance to send Jiuying away.

"You're laughing, what are you laughing about?" Jiuying lifted one eye from the messy bedding to look at her, then slowly crawled up, supporting her pale wrist with alluring eyes like silk.

"Something's wrong, you're different today. Why is your face so red? The smell in this room is also wrong - there's a floral fragrance..." Jiuying sniffed around, then suddenly seemed to know some shocking secret, her rosy mouth forming a round shape. "You, you two, you and..."

"Shh." Ning Fuyi pressed her index finger to her lips, frowning to silence her remaining words.

Jiuying's drunkenness seemed to clear immediately. Her head was no longer dizzy nor her eyes blurry. She sat properly with her legs crossed and teased: "No wonder you sent me away. If these people had told me honestly, I would have stayed far away myself."

"Just treating illness," Ning Fuyi smiled with lowered head. "My clothes are dirty, I'll change."

Jiuying crossed her arms and leaned against the bed post, her gaze following Ning Fuyi around: "Don't wear the black one - it makes you look fierce. Wear that □□¹ colored one."

Ning Fuyi's hand, which was about to throw the clothes out, stopped in mid-air. She pulled them back and shook them out, her face becoming even more heated: "This was sewn by Senior Brother Rongjin² a few years ago. He said to wear it after I came of age³. But even after coming of age, my body was still that of a child, so it's been unused all this time."

"This color..." Ning Fuyi hesitated with some distaste.

"This color is so beautiful, perfect for a girl your age. That Rongjin senior brother of yours has good craftsmanship," Jiuying supported her fragrant cheek with her pale wrist. "And perfect for meeting a lover."

Ning Fuyi shot her a sideways glance and turned to go to another room to change clothes.

"Someone who's awakened to love is truly different - like a completely changed person," Jiuying smiled and shrugged her shoulders.

Ning Fuyi put on that dress, and it fit perfectly from head to toe. Though called □□ colored, it was mostly white, bright like March spring, making even her vivid features appear gentle and soft.

When her phoenix eyes looked out the window, the sunlight illuminated her pupils to a light color.

She seemed to not have thought about falling into demonhood for a long time. She seemed to be enchanted by her current life, subconsciously indulging in it. She was no longer a waste, her loved ones were by her side, she had gained several friends, and she had Chu Qingqiu's protection.

Such days were what she had dreamed of in her previous life, what she couldn't obtain even if she fought to the death.

She gripped the white gauze of her long skirt and stood before the bronze mirror for quite a while. Jiuying swayed over from behind her, nodding in admiration.

Then she suddenly cast off her drunkenness, as if remembering something, and tapped her head. Her palm turned over, producing a crimson leafless flower: "Here, you asked me to keep an eye out that day, so I found this flower by the mountain stream."

"Although Red Spider Lilies⁴ also grow in the mortal realm, those few clearly had a different scent from ordinary ones. You couldn't smell it, but I could," Jiuying said, handing the flower stem to Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi's spirit jolted as she quickly reached out to take it. Her other hand released immortal power, and the originally bright red flower in her palm immediately turned black.

"Bone Enchantress⁵ again." Ning Fuyi gripped the flower tightly. "I knew that demon clan was definitely plotting something. Did you discover any other places?"

Jiuying touched her cheek and thought carefully: "There were some by the stream, some in the uninhabited areas at the foot of the mountain, and the most concentrated patch was in the bamboo forest behind the mountain. But because autumn is when Red Spider Lilies naturally bloom, no one noticed."

"What's this? These pitch-black flowers are from the demon realm?" she asked.

"Yes, this flower has extremely deep resentment, reproduces quickly, can hide its own aura, and can easily influence spiritual bodies and divine consciousness," Ning Fuyi rubbed the petals, squeezing out thick black juice. "What is that demon clan planting these around Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate for?"

"Forget it, regardless of what it is, let's remove them first," Ning Fuyi said, then turned and went out the door, heading straight for Tranquil Mountain Palace.

"Hey, wait for me!" Jiuying swayed as she got up, disappearing from the window in the blink of an eye.

Footnotes:

¹ □□ **colored** - The original text has characters that appear to indicate a specific color that was censored or unclear in the source

² **Rongjin (容锦)** - A senior brother figure who apparently cared for Ning Fuyi in her youth

³ **Came of age (及笄)** - Traditional Chinese coming-of-age ceremony for girls, typically at age 15

⁴ **Red Spider Lilies (彼岸花)** - *Lycoris radiata*, flowers associated with death and the afterlife in East Asian culture

⁵ **Bone Enchantress (骨中娇)** - A demonic flower mentioned earlier in the story that has corrupting properties